

Challenges Faced by Thai-Myanmar Refugees in Employment and Their Causes

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According to the data from the International Organization for Migration (IOM), by early 2025, over 3.33 million registered Burmese refugees had been living along the Thai-Myanmar border and within Thailand, breaking the highest historical record. **Among all, more than 60% of these refugees have remained in Thailand for over five years, making it one of Southeast Asia's longest-running refugee crises.**

“I came to Thailand around 2008 and I have stayed in refugee camps for about 15 years,” said Moe, a Myanmar refugee girl in Mae Sot. While some of the Myanmar refugees flee to Thailand to escape conflict and war in their homeland, others seek livelihood support, as incomes in Myanmar are too low to sustain their daily lives. Overall, economic reasons, including seeking employment and business opportunities, are the primary motivation for their to move to Thailand. Currently, there are approximately 2.3 million registered Myanmar refugees of working age in Thailand.

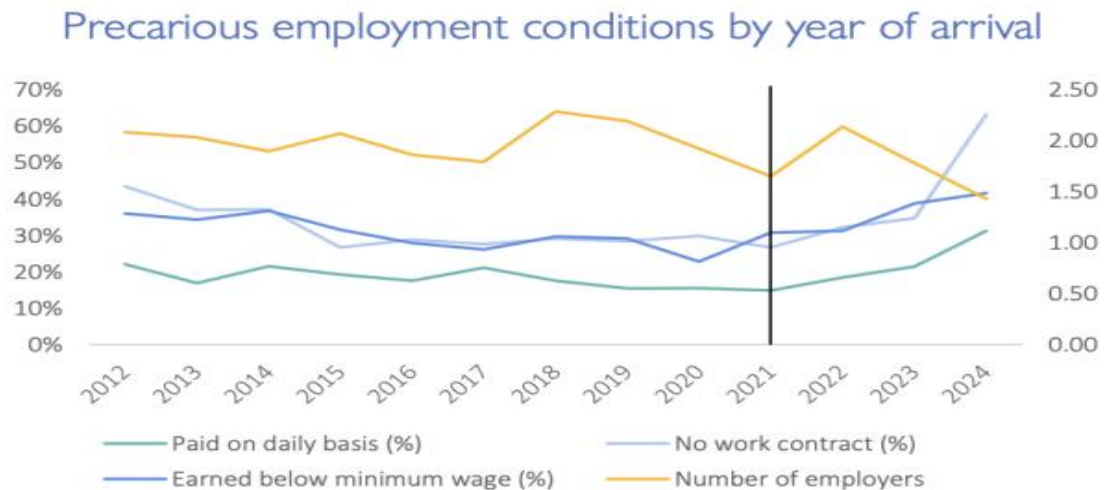
However, reality was not as they had imagined.

“I am glad that we are permitted to live in Thailand for so many years. However, as refugees, we can’t do much here since we are highly restricted.” stated by Prey, one of the refugee, “We have no means of making a living.”

Due to identity restrictions, most Myanmar refugees never live in major cities after arriving in Thailand, instead staying in mountainous regions and villages for over a decade. **Although they escape from turmoil in Myanmar, these refugees face survival challenges in Thailand, particularly encountering multiple obstacles in securing employment.**

Employment Dilemma: Informal Employment and Systemic Exploitation

In recent years, as the refugee influx has exacerbated, employment instability among Myanmar refugees in Thailand has become increasingly severe. A 2025 report by the United Nations Migration Agency (IOM) indicates that with the influx of large numbers of refugees, the number of employed individuals has shown a downward trend, while the proportion earning below the minimum wage and the proportion employed without labor contracts have both shown an upward trend.



Trends in Employment Instability Among Myanmar Refugees (by Year of Arrival)

Source: International Organization for Migration, 2025 Report

Due to identity restrictions, most Myanmar refugees are unable to secure employment through formal channels.

Till July 2024, approximately 1.7 million Myanmar refugees have been classified as undocumented, meaning they are unable to acquire the identity documents and work permits required for formal employment.

A significant portion of these undocumented refugees are confined to camps. They are unable to work legally and forced to rely on informal livelihoods. In northern Thailand, Myanmar Karen women with elongated necks earn income by developing “long-neck villages” as ethnic tourism attractions; some refugees produce and sell handicrafts with nonprofit assistance; others resort to scavenging within camps to survive.

Other refugees engage in informal employment, working in low-skilled positions across agriculture, manufacturing, fisheries, construction, and domestic service. The International Labour Organization (ILO) estimates that Myanmar migrant workers constitute approximately 80% of the labor force in these sectors within Thailand.

Even when they get employed, over one-third of refugees earn monthly incomes far below Thailand's statutory minimum wage.

Doing the same job, Thai workers often receive double or more than their Myanmar counterparts. Daily wages for refugees typically stand at 200 baht, dropping to as low as 100 baht for teens. “Last year, we visited many families in Mae Sot. Numerous children dropped out after junior high to work, earning no more than 100 baht per day,” said Hong, a scholar who has conducted a decade of field research in Thailand.

Even among the Myanmar refugees with higher education, their earnings barely cover basic living expenses. Teachers in Myanmar refugee camps earn only 5,000 baht (approximately 1,000 RMB) per month. For instance, Moe, a refugee girl working for an NGO, receives just 4,500 baht monthly.

Many refugees also have to use their meager earnings to repay migration debts. According to IMO data, nearly one-third of refugees carry debt burdens; one in four refugees earns insufficient income to cover basic expenses.

Illegal labor exploitation and restrictions on Thai employment protections further exacerbate the situation of Myanmar refugees in the job market. Without legal protections like contracts or documentation, Myanmar refugees are vulnerable to exploitation and abuse, including wage theft and violence. At a Thai flip-flop factory, Myanmar refugees frequently suffer injuries from operating high-temperature machinery, only to be fired when reporting their conditions to supervisors. According to refugees, the factory operates under the belief that undocumented workers deserve only illegal wages. “Me and the other undocumented workers only make 200 baht (about 44 yuan) a day, but we all do the same amount of work,” said refugee Myat Thida. As an undocumented worker, her income is roughly half that of documented workers.



Myanmar refugees work in fields in Thailand's northern province of Mae Hong Son, earning 300 baht (approximately 66 yuan) per day.

Source: thenewhumanitarian.org

A field research done by a Chinese social enterprise in 2024 revealed that Thai police extort bribes from Myanmar refugees by threatening deportation, creating a

gray-market industry chain. This not only intensifies the economic pressure and burden on Myanmar refugees, but also leads to a vicious cycle where deported refugees attempt to cross the border illegally again.

Additionally, Thailand's local protection policies restrict Myanmar refugees' access to employment opportunities. “In Thailand, foreigners cannot freely work as tour guides. Even with legal status, non-Thai nationals face significant barriers in many industries. The difficulties Myanmar refugees encounter in finding work in Thailand are closely tied to these local protection policies.” Scholar Hong stated, “Among the many vulnerable groups globally, the Myanmar refugee community in Thailand is one of the most needy I've encountered. They are numerous, economically disadvantaged, and subject to numerous restrictions.”

Root Causes: Language Barriers, Educational Discontinuity, and Identity Shackles

Language barriers stand as the primary obstacle. Inability to speak Thai limits Myanmar refugees' livelihood development in Thailand and their ability to protect their rights.

Research by Supang Chantavanich, a professor specializing in international migration, found that over half of Burmese refugees living in Thailand for more than five years can communicate and write in Thai. However, this does not tell the whole story.

Refugee girl Moe stated that Thai language courses offered in refugee camp schools are quite limited, only sufficient for basic communication but inadequate for educational and employment requirements. “I can understand some Thai, but I can't speak it or respond to others.”

“If we could speak Thai, we could better protect ourselves from workplace exploitation,” said Nwe Nwe Moe, a refugee from Myanmar, while participating in a Thai language training program for refugees organized by the International Labour Organization. “Language training not only helps workers communicate with employers and access public services, but also enables them to engage more actively in social dialogue. This is crucial for safeguarding their rights.” S2SR Southeast Asia Environmental Assessment Project Chief Technical Advisor stated.

Scarce educational resources create a capability gap, with high dropout rates and fragmented skills training preventing refugees from accessing quality employment opportunities.

Professor Supang's field research found that fewer than 13% of Burmese refugees complete high school (10th grade). “Many refugee children only complete primary

school, often dropping out after second or third grade with no further education,” said scholar Hong. Unlike traditional schools, Myanmar refugee schools are largely established spontaneously by the Myanmar community without government support and lack formal accreditation. Teachers are primarily Burmese nationals themselves, often with limited educational backgrounds.

Although some NGOs offer vocational training programs in Mae Sot and Bangkok that cover basic skills like sewing and cooking, these courses have limited reach, leaving many refugees without practical skill-building opportunities. “Our school only holds classes every two months, with about 20 students per class. Even though I learned how to make juice and interned at a restaurant, it doesn't guarantee I'll find a job,” Moe said during the interview.

The lack of legal status remains the root cause of issues for Myanmar refugees in Thailand. Due to identity restrictions, even young refugees who complete university education can only take low-paying jobs within the camps. “I have no legal status in Thailand. Although I received an education in the camp, our qualifications aren't recognized, so we can't find work after graduation,” said Khaing Naing, a Myanmar refugee born in Mae La camp. “Many Myanmar refugee children born in Thailand don't even have legal status.”



Myanmar refugees wait in a Thai refugee camp to register their infants' births, an important step in preventing statelessness.

Source: United Nations website

In Thailand, refugees seeking legal employment status must possess valid identification documents, including a refugee card (UN Card) issued by the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR) and a work permit granted by the Thai government. However, according to UNHCR data, approximately 40% of Burmese refugees lack legal identity documents, and over 60% do not hold valid work permits.

Furthermore, Myanmar refugees face limited ways and methods to obtain legal status. First, the process of acquiring legal identification is highly cumbersome. It requires extensive documentation and lengthy approval periods. Even if refugees complete these complex procedures, most refugee families struggle to afford the associated costs. “The cost of obtaining legal identity documents and work permits is around 10,000+ baht, equivalent to 2,000 to 3,000 RMB. This is an unattainable sum for refugees living on meager local incomes while also carrying debt burdens,” said scholar Hong.

Without legal status, refugees cannot leave the camps nor access formal employment opportunities. “If I want to leave the camp to study, work, or seek medical care in Bangkok, I need legal identity documents,” Moe explained. “So for now, I can only work for an NGO within the camp, assisting teachers with data transmission, purchasing stationery, and coordinating simple training sessions.”

Solutions: NGO Initiatives, Identity Empowerment, and Entrepreneurship Support

Numerous NGOs provide employment support to refugees locally through initiatives such as funding education and advocating for the rights of Myanmar laborers.

In Mae Sot, organizations like the Borderline dedicate themselves to lifting Burmese refugees out of poverty through educational programs and microfinance. They generate income for refugees by selling handicrafts made by Myanmar women. Additionally, they organize female refugees to operate cafes and art galleries in Mae Sot.

Other organizations like AWO focus on helping Myanmar refugees resist illegal labor exploitation by employers.

An AWO organizer stated: “NGO aid programs may help in the short term, but with a union, we can win justice on our own.” To date, AWO has assisted approximately 2,000 Myanmar workers in resolving issues including dismissal disputes and inadequate health and safety protocols.

While employment for Myanmar refugees remains a systemic challenge

unlikely to be fully resolved in the short term, concrete actions can help improve conditions for some refugees.

“If we can do anything for Myanmar refugees, especially youth, it primarily involves addressing identity status and providing entrepreneurial support,” said scholar Hong. “On one hand, we can select one or two young people to help them obtain legal status, which typically costs around 2,000 to 3,000 RMB per person. Let’s examine the impact of resolving identity status. On the other hand, we can provide seed funding for entrepreneurial support, such as becoming a landlord. We could help a refugee student rent a house, establish a Safe House, and rent it to local youth students. By managing such a property as a small sublandlord and earning rental income, isn’t this a viable small business venture?”

Education empowerment, legal identity, and entrepreneurial support—each small act of assistance is gradually transforming the “survival crisis” faced by 3.33 million Myanmar refugees into “development opportunities.”

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